

PATNA

The Discovery of Bihar

Thirty-eight months after taking over as chief minister, Nitish Kumar has finally pitched tents in the backwaters of Bihar to get a first-hand feel about his people's problems. On his 'Vikas Yatra', Kumar will stay in specially-designed Swiss cottages built by Buxar jail inmates and he will be accompanied by an assortment of departmental secretaries.

Leaders of the opposition RJD have picked on Kumar's Bihar—Ek Khoj yatra, calling it a proxy election campaign, a claim strenuously denied by the chief minister. What he has not been able to silence is the Opposition's highlighting his use of copters on the tour. They say that Kumar has taken the aerial route to avoid rural Bihar's notoriously pot-holed roads. *by Amitabh Srivastava*

NITISH KUMAR



KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN

MUMBAI

Friends Turn Foes

The Shiv Sena and the BJP are at loggerheads again, this time over Karnataka's Marathi-speaking majority district of Belgaum.

Incensed over 'police atrocities' on Marathis, the Sena wants to snap ties with the BJP. The BJP, ruling in Karnataka and an alliance partner in Maharashtra, is looking for an amicable solution.

by Aditi Pai

Tulsi Ticket

Beaten from Chandni Chowk in the 2004 Lok Sabha polls, Smriti 'Tulsi' Irani was first looking for an election ticket from Gujarat. Nixed by Narendra Modi because the soap star had refused to campaign for him, Irani has now been forced to switch channels to Madhya Pradesh.



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